RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO HELEK: OLAM HABA & THE 13 PRINCIPLES

What Olam HaBa Really Is

Rambam's Introduction to Helek, Part 6

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, conclusion of the discussion of Olam HaBa, and his commentary on the rest of the Mishnah

Shiur: Part 6 of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 11 November 2025

These notes are based on the transcript of the recording.

Where We Are

Over recent weeks: **Mashiach, techiyat hametim, Gan Eden and Gehinom** in the Rambam's understanding, against **Rav Saadia** (Monday nights) and the **Ramban**. **All secondary.** Tonight: **the primary, Olam HaBa**, then perhaps a start on the 13 Principles.

"**This coming paragraph is extremely important.** It summarises the Rambam's whole philosophy: of Judaism, of life, of Olam HaBa, of reward and punishment. **This paragraph is everything, really.**"

Part 1: The Paragraph

והתכלית הוא העולם הבא, ולמענו ההשתדלות.

The goal is Olam HaBa, and for it is all the effort.

Olam HaBa, for the Rambam: **consciousness of Hashem; souls; understanding; a person's identity.**

ולפיכך זה החכם המחזיק בידיעת האמת עיין בתכלית האחרון והניח מה שזולתו, ואמר: כל ישראל יש להם חלק לעולם הבא.

So **Rabbi Yehudah HaNasi**, "the sage who held fast to the truth," looked to **the final goal** and set the rest aside: the Mishnah says **Olam HaBa**, not Mashiach, not resurrection.

But don't serve for it

ועם היותו התכלית המבוקש, אינו ראוי למי שרוצה לעבוד מאהבה שיעבוד להשיג העולם הבא.

Though it's the goal sought, one who wants to serve from love shouldn't serve in order to attain Olam HaBa.

How, then?

אבל יש לעבוד על הדרך שאומר: כשיאמין שיש שם חכמה, והיא התורה, שהגיעה לנביאים מאת הבורא יתעלה, שהודיע בה המדות הטובות, והן המצות, והמדות הרעות, והן העבירות, ראוי לו מצד שהוא אדם ישר במזג שיעשה הטובות ויסור מן הרעות.

1. **There is objective wisdom: the Torah**, revealed to **Moshe and all the prophets**.

2. In it Hashem made known **the good traits, which are the mitzvot**, and **the bad traits, which are the sins**."**Look how the Rambam calls the mitzvot and sins: *middot tovot* and *middot ra'ot*. That's all they are.**" **Every mitzvah aims to develop either our moral character or our intellect.** He says it in many places.
3. So **a balanced, upright human being** will simply **do the good and avoid the bad**. "**Not because there's Olam HaBa afterwards. Because this is the best way to create the best version of myself.**"

וכשיעשה זה, ישלם בו ענין האנושי, ויהיה נבדל מן הבהמה.

Doing so, **he completes his humanity** and is **distinguished from the animal.**

"The key line"

וכשיהיה אדם שלם הוא — מטבע האדם השלם אשר אין לו מונע, שתחיה נפשו ותתקיים בקיום הידוע לה. וזהו העולם הבא.

When a person is complete, it's the very nature of the complete person, with nothing holding him back, that his soul lives on and endures through what it has come to know. And that is Olam HaBa.

"**Amazing.** Olam HaBa is **spending eternity in what we worked on and developed** here. What am I familiar with? **My *middot*, my intellect, Hashem.** That's what I'll spend eternity in."

"**I really don't like the word *reward***, but we have no better. There **is** reward in Olam HaBa. **But it's not what we serve for. It's the direct result of how we live.** The more developed your character and intellect, **the more you're attuned and accustomed to what Olam HaBa is**: **basking in Hashem's presence**. Hashem is ***shalem***, perfection; **the more perfect you make yourself, the more similar to Him.**"

"Don't be like a horse or a mule"

אל תהיו כסוס כפרד אין הבין, במתג ורסן עדיו לבלום (Tehillim 32)

כמו שמונע את הבהמות דבר מבחוץ כהמתג והרסן: animals are restrained **from outside**, by bit and bridle.

"Even **the best-behaved horse**, never wandering onto others' property or hurting anyone, behaves only because **its owner muzzled it**. **David says: don't be like that.** Don't keep mitzvot because *if I sin I'll burn, if I do a mitzvah I'll be rewarded*."

אבל יהיה המונע אותו מתוכו, מעצמו, רצוני לומר צורתו האנושית, כשתהיה שלמה, היא תמנענו מאותם הדברים שמונעים ממנו השלמות, והן הנקראות מדות רעות.

What holds you back must come from within: **your perfected human form** will restrain you from what blocks your completeness.

זה מה שנתבאר לי מכלל דבריהם בענין הנכבד והנעלה הזה. **He doesn't often talk like that.** *This is the* "*most elevated and important thing I'm sharing with you*."

Why it matters so much

"**I'm being repetitive because it's so important.** Many religious people serve **from fear**: *if I don't keep Shabbat or kashrut, if I eat on Yom Kippur, I'll be punished.* Or **for reward**. **That's good, better than nothing, but not the ideal.** The ideal is **an intellectual recognition** that the Torah's way is **the best way to live on planet earth. Full stop.**"

"**If you live with this, you have a completely different Judaism, a completely different relationship with Hashem and with the Torah.** Mitzvot become **exciting**, not impediments. Some religious people see sins as *things I wish I could do but can't*. **It should be: *this is best for me, so why would I endanger becoming the best person I can be?*** It's worth reviewing this paragraph again and again."

Discussion

Robert: once we reach Olam HaBa the clock stops; we can only bask.

"**Only if it's something you appreciate**, something you're **aligned with**."

Robert: some mitzvot obviously refine me; others don't. How does *sha'atnez* make me a better person, beyond obedience?

"**Remember: every mitzvah refines either character or intellect.**" For the Rambam (Moreh) **no mitzvah lacks a reason**. A ***chok*** isn't a law *without* a reason (as **Rashi**, for example, holds) but one **whose reason is harder to see**: "**both the Rambam and the Ramban are very clear.**"

Sha'atnez, the Rambam says, was **worn by pagan priests** in their idol worship. Refraining from it **awakens awareness of Hashem's unity**: **intellect and character together**.

"And *parah adumah*? I don't even understand why *tumah* is bad."

"**How it works, we don't know. Shlomo didn't.** But **revelation tells us *tumah creates a barrier between us and purity, and that the heifer purifies, and purification makes me better. The Rambam doesn't say you must understand why these eight sheratzim*** defile. **Within revelation, every mitzvah leads back to character or intellect.** *Lulav*, for example: we're praying for **rain**, recognising that **all sustenance comes from Hashem**." "*Happy to continue offline.*"

Richard: this isn't one of the 13 Principles. Shouldn't it be printed with them?

"**It's beyond a principle. It's the basis of everything.** One of the most important things we've ever learned together. **The problem is we fall into routine and forget**, which is why we keep reminding ourselves."

Part 2: The Book He Never Wrote

And in that work I'll gather all the *derashot* in the Talmud and explain them: which are **literal**, which **parables**, which were **dreams** (e.g. **Rabbi Yishmael seeing Hashem wearing tefillin** in Berachot: "**a dream, with a deeper message**"), with **many principles of faith**.

He never wrote it. In the **Moreh** he explains why: **flesh out the *derashot* fully** and you expose what the Sages **meant to keep partly hidden**; **substitute other parables**, and "**why would my parable be better than the Sages'?**" **So he abandoned it.** "**Such a shame. It would have been incredible.**"

He was in his early twenties when he wrote this introduction: "this deep concept, in his early 20s."

"I wasn't philosophically precise": deliberately, to lay out **a most important principle simply**, "**so everyone can understand it**."

Part 3: The Rest of the Mishnah

ואלו שאין להם חלק לעולם הבא: האומר אין תחיית המתים מן התורה, ואין תורה מן השמים, ואפיקורוס.

Apikoros

ומלת אפיקורוס היא ארמית, וענינה מי שמפקיר ומבזה את התורה או לומדיה: from **הפקר**, treating the Torah or its students **as worthless**. **So anyone who doesn't believe in the foundations of the Torah is called an *apikoros*, as is one who disgraces Sages, any Torah scholar, or his own teacher.**

- **Disgracing a Sage isn't heresy in itself**, but it's called *apikorsut* for its **consequence**: the Sages **carry the tradition**; despise them, and **you'll stop keeping and come to deny the Torah**.
- **The real etymology:** "**The Rambam knew perfectly well it comes from *Epicurus*.**" He quotes Epicurus in the Moreh as a heretic, and **Rav Yosef Albo** says so explicitly. "The Sages probably knew too, and **played on the word**. **He's following the Gemara's *derashah*.**"

Reading "external books"

Rabbi Akiva: אף הקורא בספרים החיצונים. The Rambam: books of those in error: **heresy**.

Hilchot Avodah Zarah: don't read idolaters' books or even **dwell on** their views, **because human understanding is limited**, and people are easily swayed, **"especially by something printed in a book."** You'll start to doubt Hashem's unity, **whether the Torah is true**, **whether revelation happened**. **ולא תתורו אחרי לבבכם.**

But rabbis read them. "**Rabbi Sacks**, *zichrono livrachah* (his yahrzeit is this week), often quoted heretical books. **The Rambam** quotes heretical views throughout the Moreh. **The Meiri**, and everyone agrees: **you may read them in order to know how to answer them. Not just for fun or curiosity.**"

The God Delusion. "A student once read **Richard Dawkins'** book; he said it **shattered his faith**. I hadn't read it, **so I did**, and we had a long conversation. **That's the kind of reason.**"

Ben Sira

The Gemara adds Ben Sira: by the Rambam's account, **"nonsense" about physiognomy**, reading **faces and palms**, **a waste of time**. Likewise **Arabic chronicles**, genealogies of kings, **song books**: **no wisdom and no bodily benefit, just lost time.**

(Physiognomy, the class found: "once considered a science, now widely regarded as a pseudoscience. The Rambam already knew.")

Who was Ben Sira? A **midrash** (cited by **Maharam Mintz**) says he was **Yirmeyahu's son**, conceived when a woman bathed **after** Yirmeyahu in a bathhouse; **Sira** = **Yirmeyahu** in *gematria*. "Scientifically impossible, but it has **halachic ramifications**." **The Chelkat Mechokek and Beit Shmuel** (Even HaEzer) ask, citing it: **has such a father fulfilled *pru u'revu***, and is the child his? **The *poskim* learn from it about artificial insemination.**

Robert: isn't that learning halachah from aggadah? "**When there's nowhere else to learn from, most hold you may.**"

Why lose Olam HaBa for nonsense books? *(Notably, Hilchot Teshuvah ch. 3 omits this.)*

1. **A cause of a cause**: nonsense leads to reading anything, including **heresy**.

2. **The Yerushalmi: Ben Sira forbidden, Homer permitted**, "**like reading a letter**." Why? **Ben Sira is written in Tanach's style**, so readers **mistake it for scripture**. "**No one reading Homer thinks they're reading Tanach.**"

Healing with verses

הלוחש על המכה... כל המחלה אשר שמתי במצרים לא אשים עליך כי אני ה׳ רפאך: **with spitting**, a pagan practice, **a disgrace to Hashem**.

The Mishneh Torah (Hilchot Avodah Zarah) goes further, "**most people are shocked when they read it, because so many people do this**":

One who **recites a verse over a wound**, or **over a child so he won't be frightened**, or **puts a Sefer Torah or tefillin by an infant so he'll sleep**: **not only are they diviners and charmers, they're among those who deny the Torah**, **for they make the words of Torah a cure for the body, when they are only a cure for the soul**: **והיו חיים לנפשך**.

But a healthy person may recite verses and Tehillim **so that the merit of reciting protects him**.

"Like the **tiny Tehillim** or ***Raziel HaMalach*** under a child's pillow. **The Torah is to study and learn from**, not for **financial** or **health** gain."

Pronouncing the Name

Abba Shaul: ההוגה את השם באותיותיו: saying **the four-letter Name** as written, in one go. (**Rashi**: the **42-letter** Name.) "There's a sect of Christians named after it ('**something's Witnesses**'). **Never say that word.**"

And more, from elsewhere

המלבין פני חברו ברבים, המכנה שם לחברו, המתכבד בקלון חברו: **shaming someone publicly**, **calling people nicknames**, **building yourself up on another's disgrace**.

Why lose Olam HaBa for "light" sins? Only someone of a deficient soul would do these, **lacking the completeness Olam HaBa requires**. "**A *siman, not a sibah***, as we'd say in yeshivah: **a sign, not a cause.**" **Hilchot Teshuvah:** it means **habitually**. "**Embarrass someone once**, it's wrong, but you won't lose Olam HaBa."

Summary

1. **The paragraph that holds everything:** the goal is **Olam HaBa**, **but don't serve for it**. Believe the Torah is **revealed wisdom** showing the **good traits (mitzvot)** and **bad (sins)**, and **do good because it's right**. Then **you become complete**, and **a complete soul endures in what it knows: that is Olam HaBa.**
2. **Not like a horse with a bit**: the restraint must come **from within**, from **our perfected humanity**. Fear and reward: "**better than nothing, not the ideal.**"
3. **Every mitzvah develops character or intellect**: even **sha'atnez** (against idolatry) and **parah adumah** (within revelation).
4. **The *derashot* book** was **abandoned**: full exposure would betray the Sages' concealment.
5. **The Mishnah's list:** the ***apikoros*** (a play on *hefker*; really **Epicurus**); **heretical books** (allowed **to answer them**: **Dawkins**); **Ben Sira**, mistakable for scripture (unlike **Homer**); **verses as medicine** (even **tefillin by a baby's pillow**, per the Mishneh Torah); **the Name**; and habitual **shaming, nicknaming, self-aggrandising**: **signs, not causes**.

Coming Up

ומה שצריך שנזכיר בכאן... עיקרי דתנו ויסודותיה, והם שלשה עשר יסודות.

Next week: the concept of principles of faith, and **Principle 1**. "Very short in the Rambam, but there's so much to discuss."

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